

# Steven Denney, Ph.D.

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## Short Bio

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I study the relationship between political institutions and individual preferences, with a focus on national identity, migration attitudes, and political behavior in East Asian democracies. My work combines surveys, experiments, and computational text analysis. I also maintain an active program of applied research on innovation policy, entrepreneurship, and the digital economy.

## Academic Positions

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| Current   | <b>Leiden University Institute for Area Studies (LIAS)</b><br>Assistant Professor [ <i>Universitair Docent</i> ] of International Relations and Korean Studies |
| 2021–2023 | <b>University of Vienna, Department of East Asian Studies</b><br>University Lecturer [ <i>Post-Doc Universitätsassistent*innen</i> ] in East Asian Studies     |
| 2019–2021 | <b>University of Toronto, Munk School of Global Affairs and Public Policy</b><br>Postdoctoral Research Fellow                                                  |

## Education

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| 2013–2019 | <b>University of Toronto</b><br>Ph.D., Department of Political Science |
| 2011–2013 | <b>Yonsei University</b><br>M.A., Global Affairs and Policy            |
| 2005–2008 | <b>Harding University</b><br>B.A., Department of Political Science     |

## Teaching

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| Current   | <b>Leiden University</b><br>Digital Korea: Introduction to Computational Text Analysis; Digital Humanities; BA Thesis Seminar; International Relations; Regions in World Politics; Methodologies in the Social Sciences and Humanities (MA/PhD); Issues in Korean Studies |
| 2021–2023 | <b>University of Vienna</b><br>Research Seminar for the Master's and PhD Thesis; Political Systems in East Asia; International Relations in East Asia; Nations and Nationalism in East Asia                                                                               |
| 2013–2021 | <b>University of Toronto</b><br>Methods in Political Science; Political Economy of East Asian Development; Introduction to Comparative Politics                                                                                                                           |

## Technical Qualifications

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| <b>Languages</b> | English (native), Korean (advanced; C2), Spanish (intermediate; B2), German (beginner; B1), Dutch (beginner; A1/2)                            |
| <b>Analysis</b>  | R, Python, Stata, and NVivo for quantitative and qualitative analysis; OCR and large language models for text extraction and classification   |
| <b>Methods</b>   | Survey and experimental design (conjoint, list, framing); computational text analysis; content and discourse analysis; qualitative interviews |

## Administration & Supervision

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| <b>Admin</b>       | Member, Board of Examiners for Asian Studies, Faculty of Humanities, Leiden University (current); Vice-Director of Study Program, East Asian Economy and Society (EcoS), University of Vienna (2022–2023) |
| <b>Supervision</b> | BA and MA thesis students conducting primary source research on Korea and East Asia, qualitative comparative designs, and quantitative social science                                                     |

## Research Grants & Fellowships (USD)

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Grants administered as Primary Investigator marked with \* and Co-Investigator marked with †

- [1] "Textbooks, Nation, and Artificial Intelligence: Reconstructing Korean National Identity." Academy of Korean Studies (AKS), 2026–2028. (\$19,262)\*
- [2] "Fairness or Threat? Understanding Sources of Immigration Backlash in Democracies." Netherlands Organisation for Scientific Research (NWO), SSH - XS 2025, 2025–2026. (\$57,000)\*
- [3] "Integration Challenges and Opportunities in Divided Countries: A Comparative Analysis of Germany and South Korea." IFES-MOU Overseas North Korea-Unification Policy Academic Research Grant, 2023–2024. (\$40,000)\*
- [4] "Who Belongs to the Nation? National Identity and Migrant Integration in South Korea." Academy of Korean Studies (AKS) Research Grant, AKS-2023-R018, 2022–2023. (\$13,500)\*
- [5] "Measuring the Impact of the Digital Economy." Facebook Research Grant, 2021–2023. (\$100,000)†
- [6] "Neighbors, Employees, and Representatives: Why Do Some North Korean Migrants Integrate and Others Don't?" Academy of Korean Studies (AKS) Research Grant, AKS-2021-R-083, 2020–2021. (\$25,000)†
- [7] "Information Dissemination in North Korea: The Role of Social Networks, Markets, and Social Change." National Endowment for Democracy (NED) Research Grant, 2020–2021. (\$60,000)†
- [8] "The Scale-up Challenge? Obstacles to High-Growth Technology-based Firms and the Policy Response." Mitacs–SSHRC Accelerate Grant, Award No. IT10712, 2017–2021. (\$150,000)\*
- [9] "Politics and Process of 'Unification in Action'." UniKorea Fund Grant Program, 2018–2019. (\$40,000)\*
- [10] "Reproducing Contested Korean Identities and Social Structures on the Korean Peninsula." Academy of Korean Studies (AKS) Research Grant, AKS-2015-R49, 2015–2016. (\$16,000)†
- [11] "Documenting Cultural and Political Information Strategies on the Korean Peninsula, 2012–2013." Academy of Korean Studies (AKS) Research Grant, AKS-2013-R11, 2012–2013. (\$15,000)†
- [12] Academy of Korean Studies (AKS), Pre-Doctoral Fellowship, 2016. (\$9,000)
- [13] Richard Simeon Doctoral Student Scholarship, University of Toronto, 2016. (\$5,000)
- [14] School of Graduate Studies (SGS) Research Grant, University of Toronto, 2016. (\$5,000)
- [15] Ontario Graduate Scholarship (OGS) Visa Award, University of Toronto, 2014. (\$25,000)

## Research & Publications

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### Peer-Reviewed Articles

- [1] Denney, S., Steinhardt, H. Christoph, & Bhowmick, L. (2026). Identity conformity in Taiwan and South Korea: Why citizens in divided societies are pressured to overstate national pride. *Nationalism and Ethnic Politics*. doi:10.1080/13537113.2026.2616954
- [2] Denney, S., Zhou, T., & Brehm, R. (2025). From division to democracy: Integration of post-communist citizens in Germany and South Korea. *Communist and Post-Communist Studies*. doi:10.1525/cpcs.2025.2636997
- [3] Ward, P., & Denney, S. (2025). Welfare chauvinism in divided societies: The role of national identity in social policy preferences. *Policy and Society*. doi:10.1093/polsoc/puaf027
- [4] Ward, P., & Denney, S. (2025). Partisan voters in party systems with ephemeral parties: Evidence from South Korea. *Party Politics*. doi:10.1177/13540688251339976
- [5] Denney, S., Ward, P., & Green, C. (2024). 한국인의 남북통일 방식에 대한 의식 결정 요인 분석: 컨조인트 분석 조사를 중심으로 [Analyzing the determinants of South Korean attitudes toward Korean unification: A conjoint analysis]. *국가전략* [National Strategy], 30(1), 137–163. doi:10.35390/sejong.30.1.202402.006
- [6] Green, C., & Denney, S. (2024). Why do democratic societies tolerate undemocratic laws? Sorting public support for the National Security Act in South Korea. *Democratization*, 31(1), 113–131. doi:10.1080/13510347.2023.2258082
- [7] Denney, S., & Green, C. (2024). Public attitudes towards co-ethnic migrant integration: Evidence from South Korea. *Journal of Ethnic and Migration Studies*, 50(8), 1998–2022. doi:10.1080/1369183X.2023.2286207

- [8] Denney, S., Ward, P., & Green, C. (2024). Public support for migrant entrepreneurship: The case of North Koreans in the Republic of Korea. *International Migration Review*, 58(2), 781–805. doi:10.1177/01979183231203927
- [9] Denney, S., & Ward, P. (2023). How autocracies disrupt unsanctioned information flows: The role of state power and social capital in North Korea. *Problems of Post-Communism*, 71(2), 177–191. doi:10.1080/10758216.2023.2180038
- [10] Denney, S., Breznitz, S., & Zhang, Q. (2023). Too much support? Entrepreneurial ecosystems and firm growth. *The Journal of Technology Transfer*, 49(3), 996–1015. doi:10.1007/s10961-023-10013-1
- [11] Denney, S., Wolfe, D. A., & Southin, T. (2023). Do winners pick government? How scale-up experience shapes entrepreneurs' assessments of innovation policy mixes. *Science and Public Policy*, 50(5), 858–870. doi:10.1093/scipol/scad030
- [12] Ward, P., & Denney, S. (2022). Welfare chauvinism among co-ethnics: Evidence from a conjoint experiment in South Korea. *International Migration*, 60(5), 74–90. doi:10.1111/imig.12937
- [13] Wolfe, D. A., DiFrancesco, R. J., & Denney, S. C. (2022). Localization of global networks: New mandates for MNEs in Toronto's innovation economy. *Cambridge Journal of Regions, Economy and Society*, 15(2), 323–342. doi:10.1093/cjres/rsac002
- [14] Denney, S., & Green, C. (2021). Who should be admitted? Conjoint analysis of attitudes toward immigrants in South Korea. *Ethnicities*, 21(1), 120–145. doi:10.1177/1468796820916609
- [15] Denney, S., & Green, C. (2021). North Korean patriotism: Assessing the success and failures of a nation. *Korea Journal*, 61(1), 154–185. doi:10.25024/kj.2021.61.1.154
- [16] Denney, S., Ward, P., & Green, C. (2020). The limits of ethnic capital: Impacts of social desirability on Korean views of co-ethnic immigration. *Journal of Ethnic and Migration Studies*, 48(7), 1669–1689. doi:10.1080/1369183X.2020.1797477
- [17] Denney, S., Southin, T., & Wolfe, D. A. (2021). Entrepreneurs and cluster evolution: The transformation of Toronto's ICT cluster. *Regional Studies*, 55(2), 196–207. doi:10.1080/00343404.2020.1762854
- [18] Song, J., & Denney, S. C. (2019). Studying North Korea through North Korean migrants: Lessons from the field. *Critical Asian Studies*, 51(3), 451–466. doi:10.1080/14672715.2019.1611462
- [19] Cathcart, A., Green, C., & Denney, S. C. (2014). How authoritarian regimes maintain domain consensus: North Korea's information strategies in the Kim Jong-un era. *The Review of Korean Studies*, 17(2), 145–178. doi:10.25024/review.2014.17.2.005
- [20] Denney, S. C., & Green, C. K. (2013). Towards a developmental understanding of North Korea: An institutional approach to economic reform and development. *European Journal of Korean Studies*, 15, 92–111.
- [21] Cathcart, A., & Denney, S. C. (2013). North Korea's cultural diplomacy in the early Kim Jong-un era. *North Korean Review*, 9(2), 29–42. doi:10.3172/NKR.9.2.29

### **Selected Working Papers**

- [1] "Cues of Commitment: Integration and Naturalization Support in Taiwan and South Korea," with Nicholas Fraser and H. Christoph Steinhardt. [under review]
- [2] "Measuring National Identity with Conjoint Experiments Using the Case of Taiwan," with H. Christoph Steinhardt. [under review]
- [3] "What Were They Thinking?" Using Open-Text Responses to Validate Constructs in Conjoint Survey Experiments. [under review]
- [4] "Persuasion and Prejudice: Are South Korean Attitudes Toward Immigration Open to Change?," with Isa van Dam and Christopher Green. [under review]
- [5] "Democracy and Nationalism, Reconsidered." [under review]
- [6] "Innovation Policy in Practice: Assessing Canada's Business Innovation and Growth Support Framework," with Robin Kelly and David A. Wolfe. [under review]
- [7] "Constructing the Nation: Identity and Historical Narratives in South Korean History Textbooks," with Aron van de Pol. [in progress]

## Theses

- [1] Denney, S. C. (2019). *Does democracy matter? Political change and national identification in South Korea and beyond* (Ph.D. dissertation, Department of Political Science, University of Toronto).
- [2] Denney, S. C. (2013). *Nation, state, and national economy: The early 19th century American developmental state* (M.A. thesis, Graduate School of Yonsei University).

## Books

- [1] Denney, S. C. (n.d.). *Nationalism under democracy: Why institutions matter for national identity and belonging* [manuscript under review].
- [2] Denney, S., & Lee, M. (n.d.). *Democracy at school: Authoritarian education and post-democratization citizens in South Korea and Poland* [manuscript in preparation].
- [3] Cathcart, A., Green, C., & Denney, S. C. (Eds.). (2020). *Decoding the Sino–North Korean borderlands*. Amsterdam: Amsterdam University Press.

## Book Chapters

- [1] Denney, S. C. (2024). Plus ça change? South Korean public opinion of the United States during the Trump administration. In M. Lerner & D. Fields (Eds.), *Divided America, divided Korea*. Cambridge University Press.
- [2] Denney, S. C. (2019). Democratic support and generational change in South Korea. In G. A. Brazinsky (Ed.), *Korea and the world: New frontiers in Korean studies*. Lanham, MD: Rowman & Littlefield.
- [3] Denney, S. C., Green, C., & Cathcart, A. (2016). Kim Jong-un and the practice of Songun politics. In A. Cathcart et al. (Eds.), *Change and continuity in North Korean politics*. Routledge.
- [4] Denney, S. C., & Green, C. (2016). Pockets of efficiency: An institutional approach to economic reform and development. In A. Cathcart et al. (Eds.), *Change and continuity in North Korean politics*. Routledge.
- [5] Hayes, P., Denney, S. C., et al. (2015). The implications of civic diplomacy for ROK foreign policy. In P. Hayes & K. Yi (Eds.), *Complexity, security and civil society in East Asia: Foreign policies and the Korean Peninsula*. Open Book Publishers.

## Reports & Applied Research

- [1] Denney, S. C., & Ward, P. (2023). Information dissemination in North Korea: A report for NGOs. National Endowment for Democracy (NED), January.
- [2] Denney, S. C., Vu, V., & Kelly, R. (2021). Into the scale-up-verse: Exploring the landscape of Canada's high performing firms. IPL & Brookfield Institute, December.
- [3] Denney, S. C., & Vu, V. (2021). Just out of reach: The elusive quest to measure the digital economy. Brookfield Institute, June.
- [4] Denney, S. C., & Vu, V. (2021). Scale the gap: The impact of growth barriers on women entrepreneurs in Canadian high-growth firms. Brookfield Institute, April.
- [5] Denney, S. C., Ward, P., & Abrahamian, A. (2020). North Korean refugee entrepreneurs in South Korea: Unveiling Korea's hidden potential. The Asia Foundation, December.
- [6] Denney, S. C. (2020). Political order and civic space in the Asia Pacific: A multilevel analysis of trends, 1989–2020. UNICEF Office of Global Insight and Policy.
- [7] Denney, S. C. (2019). Impact of COVID-19 on the market research community. Delvinia–Insights Association Special Report, May.
- [8] Denney, S. C., Green, C., & Ward, P. (2019). New values & old orders: Where do North Koreans fit in the new South Korea? Leiden Asia Centre, May.
- [9] Denney, S. C., & Green, C. (2018). Unification in action? The national identity of North Korean defector-migrants: Insights and implications. Korean Economic Institute of America: Academic Paper Series, October.
- [10] Denney, S. C., Green, C., & Gleason, B. (2015). The whisper in the ear: Re-defector press conference as information management tool. KEI Academic Paper Series, March.

## Selected Policy Papers & Commentary

- [1] Denney, S. C., & Green, C. (2023). Because it is good for South Korea: Public support for defector entrepreneurship. *38 North*, January.

- [2] Denney, S. C. (2022). Human rights and the future of the international order: Where does Seoul stand? *Korea On Point*, November.
- [3] Denney, S. C., & Green, C. (2022). Improving North Korean defector integration in South Korea: Survey findings and recommendations. *38 North*, May.
- [4] Denney, S. C. (2022). South Koreans support immigration, but conditions apply. Italian Institute for International Political Studies (ISPI), March.
- [5] Denney, S. C., & Vu, V. (2021). Great Canadian Survey of 2021: Insights for the Council of Canadian Innovators. IPL & Brookfield Institute, July.
- [6] Denney, S. C., & Vu, V. (2019). The COVID-19 crisis and policy preferences of Canadian technology scale-ups. IPL Research Report 2020-02, March.
- [7] Denney, S. C. (2016). Identité nationale et nationalisme nord-coréens [North Korean national identity and nationalism]. *Korea Analysis*, 11, 40–44.
- [8] Denney, S. C. (2016). «Hell Chosun», expression de l'insatisfaction de la jeunesse sud-coréenne [“Hell Chosun:” Expressions of dissatisfaction among South Korean youth]. *Korea Analysis*, 9, 42–45.

### Selected Reviews

- [1] Denney, S. (2026). Review of *Welfare Nationalism in Europe and Russia: The Politics of 21st Century Exclusionary and Inclusionary Migrations*, by Linda J. Cook. *Perspectives on Politics*.
- [2] Denney, S. (2026). Review of *Narratives of Civic Duty: How National Stories Shape Democracy in Asia*, by Aram Hur. *Korean Histories*, 5(1), 86–87.
- [3] Denney, S. (2026). Review of *North Korea's Mundane Revolution: Socialist Living and the Rise of Kim Il-sung, 1953–1965*, by Andre Schmid. *Korean Histories*, 5(1), 83–84.
- [4] Denney, S. (2024). Review of *From development to democracy: The transformations of modern Asia*, by Dan Slater and Joseph Wong. *Pacific Affairs*, 97(4).
- [5] Denney, S. (2022). Review of *After the Korean War: An intimate history*, by Heonik Kwon. *Pacific Affairs*, 95(1).
- [6] Denney, S. (2018). Review of *Park Chung Hee and modern Korea: The roots of militarism, 1866–1945*, by Carter Eckert. *Korea Journal*, 58(3), 184–190.
- [7] Denney, S. (2018). Review of *Unveiling the North Korean economy: Collapse and transition*, by Byung-Yeon Kim. *Journal of American–East Asian Relations*, 25(1), 93–96.
- [8] Denney, S. (2018). Review of *North Korea's hidden revolution*, by Jieun Baek. *Pacific Affairs*, 91(1), 176–178.
- [9] Denney, S. (2014). Review of *The Oxford handbook of the international relations of Asia*. *The Asan Forum*, 2(6).
- [10] Denney, S. (2012). To never forget, one must first know [Review of *Escape from Camp 14*, by Blaine Harden]. *Korea Review*, 2(2), 171–175.

### Selected Conferences, Workshops & Presentations

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2023–2026 only

- [1] “Identity Conformity in Taiwan and South Korea: Why Citizens in Divided Societies Are Pressured to Overstate National Pride,” Korea University, May 13, 2026.
- [2] “Constructing the Nation: Identity and Historical Narratives in South Korean History Textbooks,” Midwest Political Science Association (MPSA) Conference, April 2026.
- [3] “Fairness, Threat, and the Norms-Based Model of Immigration Legitimacy,” Midwest Political Science Association (MPSA) Conference, April 2026.
- [4] “What Were They Thinking?” Using Open-Text Responses to Validate Constructs in Conjoint Survey Experiments, Leiden University Centre for Digital Humanities (LUCDH) Lunch Lecture Series, Leiden University, March 24, 2026.
- [5] “Guardianship Democracy: Mapping Elite Rule Preferences in East and Southeast Asia,” 8th Annual Meeting of the Social Science Korean Studies Network in Europe (SoKEN), University of Duisburg–Essen, May 23–24, 2025.
- [6] “Persuasion and Prejudice: Are South Korean Attitudes toward Immigration Open to Change?,” Recalibrating ‘Skill’ in Changing Immigration Regimes, Asia Research Institute, National University of Singapore, January 16–17, 2025.

- [7] “Democracy and Nationalism: The Case of Taiwan,” American Political Science Association (APSA) Conference, September 4–8, 2024.
- [8] “Determinants of Foreign Information Use in North Korea: Research Findings and Implications,” International North Korean Studies Networking Forum, Yonsei University, August 5, 2024.
- [9] “Who Are ‘We’ and How Do We Know It? New Experimental Designs for Measuring National Identity,” Consequences of Identity Politics Workshop, University of Southampton, July 24–25, 2024.
- [10] “How Inclusive Are National Identities in East Asian Democracies? Exploring a New Conjoint Approach,” East Asia Institute, National University of Singapore, July 19, 2024.
- [11] “Public Attitudes Towards Immigrant Incorporation in South Korea, Taiwan, and Japan,” European Political Science Association (EPSA) Conference, July 4–6, 2024.
- [12] “Plus ça change? South Korean Public Opinion of the United States During the Trump Administration,” International Korean Studies Institute (IKSU) Summer School, June 19, 2024.
- [13] “Public Support for Citizenship Expansion in East Asian Democracies,” LIAS Talk Series, Leiden Institute for Asian Studies, May 15, 2024.
- [14] “The Enduring Legacy of Forced Division: Welfare Nationalism in Germany and South Korea,” Korean Studies Research Seminar, LIAS, Leiden University, April 17, 2024.
- [15] “Size or Speed? Public Attitudes toward Rising Immigration Levels in Historically Homogeneous Nations,” American Political Science Association (APSA) Conference, August 31–September 3, 2023.
- [16] “Measuring National Identity: A Choice-Based Conjoint Approach,” Midwest Political Science Association (MPSA) Conference, April 13–16, 2023.
- [17] “Why Do Democratic Societies Tolerate Undemocratic Laws? Sorting Public Support for the National Security Act in South Korea,” International Studies Association (ISA) Conference, March 15–18, 2023.
- [18] “Nationalism Under Democracy: Why Institutions Matter for National Identity and Belonging,” Ostasienforum, Department of East Asian Studies, University of Vienna, May 24, 2023.

## Academic Service & Affiliations

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| <b>Open source</b>  | Open educational resources for computational text analysis and quantitative research methods, including curated datasets, instructional materials, and corpora for Korean studies                                                                                                                                                            |
| <b>Affiliations</b> | Director of Research, SinoNK.com (current); Non-Resident Fellow, Innovation Policy Lab, University of Toronto (2019–present); Senior Fellow, European Centre for North Korean Studies, University of Vienna (2022–present); Affiliated Researcher, Leiden University Centre for Digital Humanities (LUCDH), Leiden University (2026–present) |
| <b>Reviewer</b>     | Government and Opposition, Democratization, International Political Science Review, International Migration, Asian Studies Review, Social Science Journal, Regional Studies, Communist and Post-Communist Studies, Journal of Ethnic and Migration Studies                                                                                   |
| <b>Member</b>       | International Studies Association, Association of Asian Studies, Midwest Political Science Association, American Political Science Association, European Consortium for Political Research                                                                                                                                                   |

## Other Professional Experience

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|-----------|-------------------------------------------------------------------------|
| 2020–2021 | Research Analyst & Consultant, United Nations                           |
| 2019–2021 | Research Fellow, Brookfield Institute for Innovation + Entrepreneurship |
| 2019–2021 | Deemed Employee, Statistics Canada                                      |
| 2018–2019 | Research Analyst & Consultant, E&Y / Toronto Global                     |
| 2018–2019 | Research Analyst & Consultant, Asia Foundation                          |
| 2014–2017 | Contributor & Analyst, The Diplomat                                     |